used it with great force for twelve months in 2020–21, when they camped outside Delhi demanding the repeal of the new agricultural laws that they felt would severely disadvantage them. They won that battle, as the government eventually backed down.

Walking in the Yatra was a sensory cornucopia. As one felt the vibrations of thousands of pairs of feet on the ground, trumpets and drums blared morale-boosting music, crowds lined the paths, and cheered and took photographs, the yatris shouted slogans and perhaps because I walked in Rajasthan, women dressed in the most stunning and vibrant colours stood in large groups along the route. Many had no doubt come to see Rahul Gandhi for themselves, and from the right vantage points were likely to get a better look than by going to a political rally. On the second day, as we walked through the town of Dausa, there was not an inch of ledge or rooftop that was not crammed with perilously perched crowds, and people stood six or seven deep on the sides of the road. The Congress Seva Dal and Congress veteran Jairam Ramesh led the Yatra every day. Yogendra's group, which I was part of, marched behind it, a kilometre or so ahead of Rahul Gandhi's juggernaut of the roped 'D' area, containing the media vans (producing those slick images on social media) and a security cordon where Rahul walked with those he impulsively invited in and others who had come especially to support the Yatra. He was nominally protected by security, but in truth he was a sitting duck as he walked along highways, flyovers and down narrow streets overlooked by buildings. That took great courage, having lost his father (former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi) and grandmother (former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi) to assassinations. But his manner belied this vulnerability as he walked at a brisk pace, smiling and waving to crowds, picking out individuals to enter the D and walk with him for a while.

I, too, walked with Rahul, working hard to keep pace. As on earlier encounters, I found Rahul to be courteous and cerebral, eager for an intellectual back-and-forth and easily affectionate. We debated the usefulness of Western political thought in furthering our understanding of Indian politics. He offered his own take, and our robust conversation